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INTERVIEW

Pratika Rawal and the science of staying unshakeable

The 25-year-old has built her career in **quiet defiance**, refusing to follow the path laid out for her. From quitting basketball at 16 to walking off a field with a fractured ankle because she would not take a stretcher, her story is one of decisions made on her own terms.

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Pratika Rawal has been the author of her own destiny for as long as she can remember. From choosing cricket over basketball at 16 to carving her niche as an opening batter for India, the 25-year-old loves to be in control of things around her, right down to the last detail.

Since making her international debut against West Indies last December, Pratika has smashed her way into the record books, amassing 1000 ODI runs in no time, the joint-fastest to reach the mark in the women's game (23 innings, tied with Australia's Lindsay Reeler).

The Pratika-Smriti Mandhana pairing at the top has been an imperious one in the 50-over format, becoming the fifth most successful duo in the women's game with 1799 runs in just 23 innings. Among the top five, which includes remarkable pairs like South Africa's Laura Wolvaardt-Lizelle Lee and Australia's Rachael Haynes-Alyssa Healy, the

Indian combination has the best average: a striking 78.21.

Up and up

The World Cup was lukewarm by their standards, with Pratika left shouldering responsibility after Smriti fell in five of the six batting innings she was involved in, even taking some brickbats for a slow strike rate. But it all came together in an incredible match-winning 122 against New Zealand, which sealed India's place in the knockouts. It was a 170-minute masterclass that received the cinematic treatment it deserved from the ICC digital team in the reels and highlight clips that followed.

Life was moving at a great pace before it suddenly screeched to a halt. A horrifying slip on a wet outfield in Navi Mumbai in India's last league match left her with a fractured ankle. "I am not a person who shows much emotion," Pratika tells *Sportstar*, with a foot protected by a moon boot and elevated on the

bed at home in New Delhi. "I screamed. Harleen Deol, who was at long-on, knew something was wrong as I do not usually show pain. I stood up because I don't like going out on a stretcher, that's just me. I walked into the dressing room, and my only concern was when I could go to bat!"

She wouldn't for the rest of the World Cup; her dream of seeing India through to the podium was left incomplete.

"These things can happen to any player. It's a part of sport. This isn't in my control. The only thing I could do was nurse my ankle properly. I began calculating how long it would take me to get back on the field. It was all about what to do next. All the emotions I didn't show, my dad did. I ended up having to calm him down then."

When India eventually beat South Africa to lift its maiden World Cup trophy, Smriti ensured Pratika was front and centre of the celebrations. She was wheeled into the middle of the dancing, even helped onto her